

Québec–Ontario Homeschool Diploma Pathway

Minutes of the parent information session

DATE	Wednesday, 3 September 2026
TIME	6:05 PM – 6:35 PM, online (session recorded)
LED BY	Mufti Mirza-Zain Baig — Principal, Dar Al-'Ulum Montréal; Principal, Académie internationale de Toronto
ATTENDEES	Parents of students in Secondary 3, 4, 5 and Grade 12
LANGUAGE	Session delivered bilingually in French and English
PURPOSE	Clarify the combined DES (Québec) and DESO/OSSD (Ontario) pathway, exam obligations, benefits, and the science lab arrangement

CORE MESSAGE

One pathway, two diplomas. The Québec and Ontario curricula have been merged into a single aligned program running from Secondary 3 to Grade 12. Students are not enrolled in two parallel programs and are not doing duplicate work.

1. Purpose of the session

The Principal opened by noting that last year's rollout left genuine confusion among parents: whether this is one program or two, whether it adds workload, what the benefit is, and what the portal is for. This session was called to settle those questions, walk through the Secondary 3 to Grade 12 requirements in full, and take questions from the floor.

2. Recommended pathway

Secondary 3 and 4 are completed as homeschool plus the Ontario program, while the student is under 16 and still followed by the Direction de l'enseignement à la maison through its portal. At age 16 the student is no longer eligible for that follow-up, so from Secondary 5 and Grade 12 onward the student is either followed directly by the school board or continues the full program described in this session. Exceptions apply where a student has repeated a year and is still under 16 in Secondary 4.

3. DES requirements — Québec, 54 credits

Credits begin accumulating in Secondary 4 and 5; Secondary 3 carries no credits. A passing grade of 60% is required in every course.

COURSE	LEVEL	UNITS
French, language of instruction	Secondary 5	6
English, second language	Secondary 5	4
Mathematics	Secondary 4	4
Science and Technology	Secondary 4	4
History of Québec and Canada	Secondary 4	4
Arts	Secondary 4	2
CCQ / ethics	Secondary 4	2
Physical Education	Secondary 5	—
Contemporary World	Secondary 5	4
Financial Education	Secondary 5	2

4. What Dar Al-'Ulum teaches

Secondary 4. French, English second language, Mathematics SN, Science and Technology (ST and STE), History of Québec and Canada, Arts, Physical Education and CCQ. Arts, Physical Education and CCQ are deliberately placed in Secondary 4 to lighten the Secondary 5 load. STE is taught rather than ATS because it is simpler to administer and matches the lab partner's setup.

Secondary 5. French, English second language, Mathematics SN, Physics, Chemistry, Contemporary World and Financial Education.

Grade 12. Credits are issued on the health science track by default, adjustable where a student is targeting another field.

5. Ministry exams and épreuves uniques

Each subject carries three to four competencies, and ministry exams do not evaluate all of them. History of Québec and Canada is the exception, evaluated in full by the ministry. In Mathematics Secondary 4 two competencies are ministry-evaluated and one is not; in Science and Technology one competency is ministry-evaluated, with the remaining ST and STE competencies handled by épreuve unique or by a certified teacher. French Secondary 5 and English Secondary 5 are ministry exams on selected competencies only.

MUST BE WRITTEN IN A PUBLIC SCHOOL

Four evaluations cannot be teacher-evaluated and must be sat at a public school on the ministry's dates: the two Mathematics Secondary 4 competencies, the first Science and Technology Secondary 4 competency, and the History of Québec and Canada exam. Everything else is either an épreuve unique through the school board or an evaluation by a certified teacher.

School board positions differ and this materially affects families:

SCHOOL BOARD	POSITION ON TEACHER EVALUATION
CSSDM	Permits the Principal, as a certified teacher, to evaluate subjects directly and submit those marks for credit. Done successfully in past years.
CSS de Laval	Does not accept evaluation by an outside teacher. Students must attend the board's own centre to write.
CSS de la Pointe-de-l'Île	Accepts teacher-issued evaluations, subject to specific procedural steps.

A correction was noted on the slide deck: the figure displayed should read 55, referring to the external exam.

6. The DESO / OSSD — Ontario

The Ontario Secondary School Diploma requires 30 credits, 18 compulsory and 12 optional, taken across Secondary 3 through Grade 12 at roughly six to eight courses per year. It also requires 40 hours of community involvement spread over the four years and a French-language literacy test written in the second year. Ontario mandates no provincial ministry exam, so the issuing institution sets its own final assessments and awards credits. The Principal has been designated Principal of the Académie internationale de Toronto as of this year, which carries the authority to issue those credits under Ontario ministry requirements.

The 12 optional credits have been pre-selected by the school so that all students follow one common track: Arts, Physical Education and CCQ in Secondary 4, and Financial Education and Contemporary World in Secondary 5.

7. Curriculum integration

The Principal stressed that this is not two parallel programs. The Québec and Ontario curricula were merged into a single aligned program from Secondary 3 to Grade 12, built with the partner institution over hundreds of hours, specifically so students are not duplicating work. Only Grade 9 / Secondary 3 Science carries meaningful added units; elsewhere the additions are minor. All supplementary material is Québec-based and drawn from the same Éditions CEC manuals students already use, which parents can verify from the imprint at the foot of each page.

8. Portal walkthrough

Using Mathematics MNA (Secondary 4) as the live example, the Principal showed that portal chapters mirror the manual exactly. Each lesson carries its duration, the corresponding cahier pages, the learning objectives, and video capsules for students wanting extra explanation. Completed work is photographed and uploaded to the lesson's *remise* section, then corrected with feedback returned to the student.

Two changes were made this year to reduce friction. First, any required work not appearing in the manual has been printed into a booklet already distributed to every student, so nothing needs to be printed at home. Second, every student now has one scheduled hour per week, with scanners and phones provided, purely for scanning and uploading, so that no instruction time is lost to administration.

9. Benefits of the pathway

Direct university entry. Concordia and McGill admit OSSD holders directly into their programs. Université de Montréal and UQAM require one preparatory year before entry.

Grades accumulate rather than arriving all at once. Dar Al-'Ulum, as a homeschool support service, cannot issue Québec marks, and the ministry recognises only marks entered by a school board; the school has no access to Charlemagne. Under the Ontario program marks build continuously across the year, with report cards issued in December and June. For a homeschooled student on the Québec track alone, the only mark appearing in Secondary 4 is the ministry exam result, which means a full year of strong work can be undone by one exam — and public school students, with far more preparation resources than homeschoolers have, also fail those exams.

Admission timing. A homeschooled Secondary 5 student applying to CEGEP frequently has an incomplete file at the first admission round because marks arrive only at year end, and so misses their program of choice.

A poor ministry exam mark no longer follows the student. Under the Ontario track that mark is not determinative, provided the student completes both Secondary 5 and Grade 12. Stopping after Secondary 5 forfeits both diplomas. The student then arrives at university with a consistent, complete record from Grade 9 through Grade 12.

CEGEP remains available, but the Principal questioned the point of routing through CEGEP to reach university when direct entry is available, particularly given tightening French-language rules for CEGEP admission. He noted that many private and Islamic schools across Montréal and Québec have adopted the Grade 12 program for the same reason.

10. Why the school is doing this

The Principal was explicit that the arrangement costs the school more than it takes in, and that the simpler course would be to tell parents to deal with the school board themselves. The program exists so that homeschooled students are not disadvantaged by the choice to homeschool, and so that families who withdrew children from the public system are not forced to send them back for a year simply to secure a diploma.

11. Science labs

A partnership has been secured with **GMC School**, the previous lab host having ceased operations. Sessions run Friday mornings on designated weeks, roughly monthly, with the full calendar to be circulated once GMC confirms.

LEVEL	LABS PER YEAR	FREQUENCY	GRADE ENTRY
Secondary 3	6	Approx. every six weeks	No grades entered
Secondary 4 (ST / STE)	10	Approx. monthly	Entered directly into Charlemagne
Secondary 5 (Physics, Chemistry)	10	Approx. monthly	Entered directly into Charlemagne

SCHEDULE CHANGE

The first session was set for Friday, but GMC requested a reschedule by email the previous evening. It will now be held **Wednesday 9 September, 8:30 – 9:30 AM**, covering Secondary 3, 4 and 5 together. From then on each grade receives its own time slot.

Students will receive a lab booklet from GMC to track progress and submissions. Because Secondary 4 and 5 lab grades flow straight into Charlemagne, those evaluations reach the board system without a separate submission step.

The Principal closed this section by noting how difficult and expensive the arrangement was to secure, and asked parents to treat it accordingly. Students must attend every session, arrive on time, conduct themselves well, and wear the Dar Al-'Ulum uniform, since they attend as representatives of the school. Transport by bus is available for students already travelling to Dar Al-'Ulum.

12. Questions from parents

What exactly are the "compétences"?

Each subject is evaluated across three or four competencies, visible on the year-end evaluation. French covers communication, comprehension and writing; Mathematics covers problem solving and mathematical reasoning among others. Ministry exams assess only some of them, History being the exception. The rest go through *épreuves uniques*, or for CSSDM students through the Principal's own evaluation, which counts toward board credits.

So CSSDM students are evaluated by you, and everyone else writes at a secondary school?

Correct, with the four mandatory in-school exams named in section 5 as the exception that applies to everyone.

Do parents contact the school themselves to schedule those exams?

No. The Principal will circulate the procedure after 30 September, once the *projet d'apprentissage* has been filed.

Are the 12 optional Ontario credits actually optional?

They are chosen from a list rather than skipped. The school has already selected them on behalf of all students in order to maintain one common track.

What counts toward the 40 hours of community involvement?

Ordinary volunteering, including service at the mosque, logged and recorded. The hours are spread across the four years in any distribution and are facilitated within *madrassah* hours.

Labs fall on a weekday, which makes pickup difficult for working parents.

The previous host school is no longer operating and GMC has the lab free only on Fridays, so there was no alternative. It is once a month rather than weekly, and students return to Dar Al-'Ulum afterward with bus transport available.

Can a student opt out of Mathematics SN?

Not at present. There is no CST stream, as the school is maintaining a single class rhythm. Students struggling with specific notions will be supported case by case.

13. Closing

The Principal confirmed the session was recorded and remains available to parents for replay where anything was unclear, and closed with a reminder that the first lab is Wednesday at 8:30 AM.

14. Action items

OWNER	ACTION	BY WHEN
Mufti Zain	Write to CSSDM regarding the teacher-evaluation request and contact Mme Boivin directly	Immediate
Mufti Zain	Circulate the procedure and email template for requesting the exam calendar, confirming the student will be evaluated by a certified teacher	After 30 Sep
Mufti Zain	Share the full science lab calendar once GMC School confirms the dates	On confirmation
Mufti Zain	Post confirmation of the Wednesday 9 September lab session to the parents' group	Immediate
Parents	Submit the projet d'apprentissage	30 Sep 2026
Parents	Ensure students attend the first lab in Dar Al-'Ulum uniform, 8:30 – 9:30 AM	Wed 9 Sep
Parents	Ensure the weekly scan-and-upload hour is used and portal submissions stay current	Ongoing
Parents	Ensure attendance at all scheduled lab sessions, on time and in uniform	Ongoing

Minutes recorded from the session transcript of 3 September 2026. **Dar Al-'Ulum Montréal** — Homeschool Support Program.